



LAUGHTER

Lambs to the

A critical deficit in training and a crippling absence of specialised jungle warfare schools is the biggest stumbling block in the fight against Naxalism

|By Sandeep Unnithan|

Somewhere in Chhattisgarh's Maoist-infested North Bastar district, a police patrol wearing camouflage fatigues walks through a reddish brown dust bowl at the foot of a hillock. Shots are fired. It's an ambush. In a flash, six commandos have already raised their weapons, arched their bodies into a combat shooting stance and fired accurate bursts at their unseen enemy.

Watching this counter-ambush drill impassively from the hillock—arms on his waist—is Brigadier (retired) Basant Kumar Ponwar. A soldier with a rifle-crack of a voice, Ponwar is clear about his goal. "Learn what I tell you," he tells his recruits, "or you go back home in a box."

Just a week ago, 76 policemen of the CRPF's A company and a state head constable were ambushed and killed (*see survivors account*) in Dantewada. The company hadn't been trained in jungle warfare and paid a terrible price. "The CRPF misread the ground situation. They

made a mistake and got trapped," says Chhattisgarh Director-General of Police Vishwa Ranjan.

Dantewada is a reflection of how precariously the war against red terror is perched in terms of trained manpower. Analysts say it takes a ratio of 20:1 (20 security forces to a militant) to cap an insurgency and 30:1 to break its back. The current ratio for the Maoist menace is less than 1:20. Consider the arithmetic of the war. An estimated 6,00,000 armed forces, police and paramilitary force personnel have tackled 3,000 militants in Jammu and Kashmir. Contrast this with the red corridor which exceeds 45,000 sq km across five states but is manned by approximately 60,000 policemen. Barely half of them are adequately trained to befriend the jungle and fight an estimated 15,000 militants of Maoistan.

The war against the Naxal insurgency has always been about capacities—a poorly trained, poorly led and outnumbered police force pitted against a highly motivated, well-led and equipped enemy who fights exactly like a conventional guerrilla army. This is where institutions like the Counter Terrorism and Jungle

**POLICE COMMANDOS DURING A MOCK
DRILL AT THE CTJW COLLEGE IN KANKER**